

Cemetery Highway

This next song started on a small Virginia highway.

I was driving with my daughter Caroline along Route 229 past a little cemetery. A hard wind had blown the plastic flower arrangements off the graves. They'd been carried across the road and were scattered in the ditch on the other side.

As we passed, I said out loud, "That would make a good song."

But later, it stayed with me. Those flowers — separated from the place they were meant to rest. And that cemetery reminded me of another one... in Wright, Kansas.

That's where my cousin Gregg is buried. He was nineteen years old when he was killed in Vietnam in the summer of 1970.

He dropped out of college, and he and his friend Ricky left for Vietnam looking for adventure. They both came home that same summer in flag-draped coffins.

I was just a kid when it happened. I didn't really know how to carry something like that. I still don't.

This song isn't exactly about Gregg. And it isn't exactly about war.

It's written from the perspective of his friend Ricky — imagining what it would be like if at least Ricky would have lived. If Ricky were an old man now... standing at Gregg's grave, looking at the portrait of a nineteen-year-old who never got older.

Most of my songs are sadder than real life. But in this song, at least one of them survives the war. So, perhaps, not as sad as real life.

This is called "Cemetery Highway."